

MGT 410: Competitive Strategy (FE)

TERM: Fall 2026

SECTION ID: E 00004662

TUESDAY 6:30pm-9:20pm, OTRSN 1E107

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OFFICE HOURS: By Appointment (In-Person and Virtual)

TEACHING ASSISTANT/TUTOR: TBD

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DESCRIPTION

This course focuses on strategic decision making by companies in competitive markets. The approach will combine applied economic theory with empirical examples to develop competitive advantage and game theory frameworks. Classes will consist of both lecture and discussion of applications, including case studies.

OBJECTIVES

At the close of this course, you will be able to:

- Identify sources of profit within and across industries
- Understand how to create and sustain a business's competitive advantage
- Direct how a company should grow, innovate and respond to changing markets
- Analyze strategic interactions between competing and complementary companies
- Shape the nature of industry competition to your advantage
- Use strategic frameworks to communicate within and across businesses

MATERIALS

Required Course Packet. The course packet contains the readings, case studies and articles for the course. It is available at the **Study.Net Materials** link through Canvas.

Canvas. All materials not included in the course packet will be posted on Canvas. This includes lecture notes and practice exams. In addition, readings and assignments are subject to change. Please check Canvas regularly for updated materials.

Supplementary texts. The following texts are good resources for additional background on topics covered in the class. These are optional and not required.

Besanko, David, David Dranove, Mark Shanley and Scott Schaefer. *Economics of Strategy, Seventh Edition*. John Wiley & Sons, 2017. Referred to below as BDSS.

Dixit, Avinash K., and Barry Nalebuff. *The Art of Strategy: A Game Theorist's Guide To Success In Business & Life*. WW Norton & Company, 2008.

GRADING

Assignments	Percentage
Group case write-ups (3 total):	30
In-Class Exam	35
Final Group Project	35
Total	100

DELIVERABLES

Class Participation and Attendance

Participation and attendance will not be tracked or graded explicitly. Both are strongly encouraged, since they will not only make you better off, but also improve your classmates' learning experiences and outcomes. If you cannot make it in-person to any of the final 3 sessions (where we have our in-person exam and class presentations), please let me know in advance and we can find a way to accommodate you. Advanced notice isn't necessary if you don't make it to any of the first 7 sessions.

- The quality of your participation is essential for the class to work. This includes interactive lectures, case discussions, and class activities.
- Participation also includes writing your name on a name card in class.
- Please do your best to attend every class since active case discussion is an important learning opportunity.

Group Case Write-ups

You may choose your study group of 4-6 people. Each group will submit 3 write-ups during the quarter.

- A brief response to write-up questions, which we'll post on Canvas.
- You may use bullet points. Aim for 1-2 pages (double spaced, 12-point font and 1-inch margins). Do not include appendices. The motivation for short write-ups is to encourage you to think carefully about the most relevant information to include, rather than attempting to include all information.
- Try to minimally discuss the cases with members outside your group before we talk about them in class. This is so that we have a diverse range of perspectives, examples and arguments for our in-class discussion, which will make for a much more interesting session.
- Upload write-ups to Canvas by the start of class.

Think of the case write-up as a tool to help you prepare for the in-class discussion of the case. In class, you should be prepared to summarize the case, answer the case questions, and provide supporting evidence for your argument. The write-up should be easy to read, tie in relevant theoretical material, and draw appropriate conclusions using the frameworks we discuss in class.

Exam

There will be one in-person exam, which will be closed-book, closed-note and no cheat sheets. Closer to the exam date, I will let you know if calculators will be permitted.

Group Strategy Project

You may choose your group of 4-6 people. The main project in the course is an analysis of a company to be completed with your team. The first step will be for you as a team to select a company to work on

throughout the course. After receiving confirmation of your company, you will write two (2) sections and develop a final presentation to conclude as detailed below.

Goals

The goal of these assignments is to have you practice the skills necessary to do competitive analysis on your own. Given that, the structure of the assignment is designed to match the structure of a competitive analysis you will do on the job.

Executives making strategic decisions often have limited time. Thus we will require these deliverables to be very short but very substantive. Each portion of the assignment will require significant thinking and refining. The teams that do the best will write something several times the length of the final assignment and then whittle it down to its essence for the final submission.

Written Component

The three components of this project are: (A) a written Five Forces Industry Analysis, (B) a written Positioning Analysis, and (C) Presentation of Problem and Recommendation of a Solution and final presentation and slides. You will get more information about the parameters of the final project separately.

The first two written portions of the write-up should not exceed 3 pages (double spaced, 12-point font and 1 inch margins). We will only read the first 3 pages of text, so please stay within the page limit. The limit does not include a cover page or appendices, which you can use to provide charts, figures, or other background material, but these sections should be no longer than five (5) additional pages. The appendix is not a catch-all for anything that might be relevant, but is to be used to carefully support your points. Always include page numbers.

Presentation Component

The Presentation of Problem and Solution will take place on the last day of class and your team will present a key problem your client is facing and offer a solution to that problem. This presentation should include an executive summary slide and will also include the findings from your analyses where relevant. Each team member is encouraged to take a role in the final presentation. Additional guidelines (e.g., time) will be announced. Part of your participation grade in the course will involve asking questions to the other groups when they present.

SCHEDULE

For our schedule, see the syllabus page on Canvas.

AI POLICY

I am a big fan of AI as a learning tool. It can really help things “click”. USE IT! Have conversations with it, push back against it if what it’s saying isn’t making sense. You may use it as you prepare your write-ups, to help you study for the exam, and as you work on your final projects. Just remember that

- 1) **You won’t be able to use it on the exam.** The exam is where you’ll show me you know the material inside and out. I don’t mind if AI helped it “click” for you along the way.
- 2) **You won’t be able to use it while you present and field questions during your final presentation.** Once again, I don’t mind if AI helped you prepare, but when you’re in front of the class presenting your part of your group’s project, you want it to be clear as day that you have a firm grasp of every point you’re saying and question you’re answering.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:
<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.